

Max-Efficiency Hypertrophy Program

4 days/week Upper/Lower split built on Andy Galpin's hypertrophy principles: minimum effective dose, training close to failure, rep-range variety. Extra volume on chest, side delts and traps.

Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Upper A	Lower A	Rest	Upper B	Lower B	Rest	Rest

Days can shift; keep at least one rest day between the two Upper sessions.

Effort Most sets at RIR 0-2. The single biggest lever for growth.	Rep spectrum 5-8 reps recruit big motor units via load; 15-20 via fatigue. Both, every week.	Volume 10-20 hard sets per muscle per week. More than that is fatigue, not growth.
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Progression Add reps inside the range; hit the top on all sets, add weight, restart at the bottom.	Deload Every 5-6 weeks cut volume ~40% for one week.	Adherence Bag packed the night before, session decided in advance. Weeks 1-3 are an adherence experiment, not a gains experiment.
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Upper A

Exercise	Sets x Reps	RIR	Target
Barbell Bench Press	3 x 5-8	1-2	Chest
Incline DB Press	3 x 8-12	1-2	Upper chest
Weighted Pull-up / Lat Pulldown	3 x 8-10	1-2	Back
Lateral Raise (DB)	4 x 15-20	0-1	Side delts
Face Pull	3 x 15-20	1-2	Rear delts
Incline DB Curl (superset A1)	3 x 10-15	0-1	Biceps
Overhead Cable Triceps Ext. (A2)	3 x 10-15	0-1	Triceps

Lower A

Exercise	Sets x Reps	RIR	Target
Back Squat	3 x 5-8	1-2	Quads / glutes
Romanian Deadlift	3 x 8-10	1-2	Hamstrings
Leg Press / Walking Lunge	3 x 10-12	1-2	Quads
Calf Raise	3 x 12-15	0-1	Calves
Neck Curl (flexion)	3 x 15-20	2	Neck (front)
Lateral Neck Flexion	3 x 15-20 / side	2	Neck (sides)

Upper B

Exercise	Sets x Reps	RIR	Target
Overhead Press	3 x 6-10	1-2	Delts
Weighted Dip / Flat DB Press	3 x 8-12	1-2	Chest
Barbell Shrug	4 x 10-15	0-1	Traps (priority)
Barbell Row	3 x 8-12	1-2	Back / traps
Cable Lateral Raise	3 x 15-20	0-1	Side delts
Farmer's Carry	3-4 x 30-40 m	heavy	Traps / grip
EZ-Bar Curl (superset A1)	3 x 8-12	1-2	Biceps
Triceps Pushdown (A2)	3 x 10-15	0-1	Triceps

Lower B

Exercise	Sets x Reps	RIR	Target
Deadlift / Trap Bar Deadlift	3 x 5	1-2	Posterior chain
Bulgarian Split Squat	3 x 10 / leg	1-2	Quads / glutes
Leg Curl	3 x 10-12	1-2	Hamstrings
Calf Raise	3 x 12-15	0-1	Calves
Neck Extension	3 x 15-20	2	Neck (back)
Lateral Neck Flexion	3 x 15-20 / side	2	Neck (sides)

Arms and neck

Arm supersets

Curl, then the triceps move straight away, then rest 90 s. Opposing muscles don't steal from each other, so this adds ~8 min instead of 15. About 6 direct + indirect sets per week lands arms at 10-12 effective sets.

Neck: start light

A 2.5-5 kg plate is plenty for weeks 1-4. Slow and controlled, 2 reps short of failure, never jerk. Progress by reps first, weight later. Neck muscles grow fast but tolerate sudden loading badly.

Wider neck = 3 parts

Sides and front (neck flexion work), back (extension), and upper traps (shrugs, carries, deadlifts). All three are in the program; width shows mostly from the traps and sides.

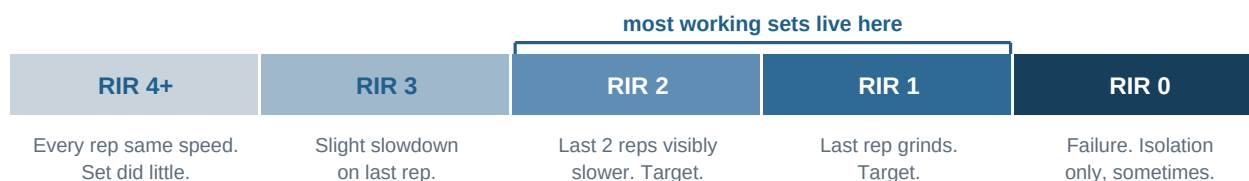
Order matters

Weak points go first while you're fresh. On Upper B, move shrugs to second if traps feel like the bigger gap that day. Tempo: 2-3 s controlled down, explosive up. Slowing the eccentric is free tension; slowing the concentric is just fatigue.

RIR - Reps In Reserve

How many more reps you could have done when you stopped. RIR 0 is failure; RIR 2 means two clean reps were left. It doses effort without needing a 1RM percentage.

Effort -> harder



Making it objective

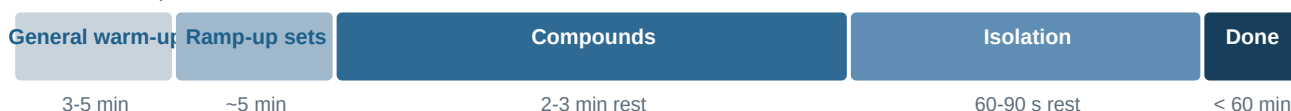
Everyone overestimates reps in reserve at first. Three checks, used together, get you to +/-1 rep within 4-6 weeks:

1. Failure calibration Week 1: take the last set of each isolation exercise (lateral raises, leg curls, calves) to true failure. Note the reps. Next session, stopping 2 short of that number at the same weight is RIR 2. Repeat once per mesocycle.	2. Bar speed On compounds, the last 2-3 reps before failure slow down involuntarily. All reps the same speed = RIR 4+. Last rep grinding = RIR 0-1. Film one set from the side; it's obvious on video.	3. The log If you've been at 3 x 8 with 60 kg for two weeks and it won't become 9, you are already near RIR 1-2. The numbers know before the feeling does.
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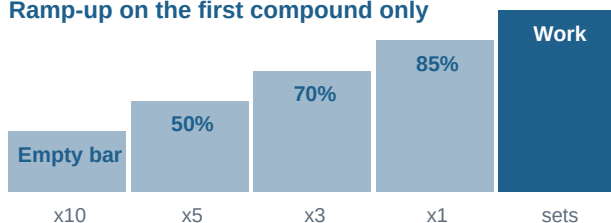
Calibrate with 1, judge compounds with 2, cross-check with 3.

Warm-up and session flow

One session, start to finish



Ramp-up on the first compound only



General warm-up (3-5 min): bike, rower, or a brisk walk in. Enough to raise temperature, no more. Mornings need this more: you are stiffer and the spine has rehydrated overnight, so never skip it before squats or deadlifts.

Ramp-up: only on the first compound of the session, ~1 min between ramp sets. Later exercises get at most one feeler set. Isolation work gets none - straight to working weight.

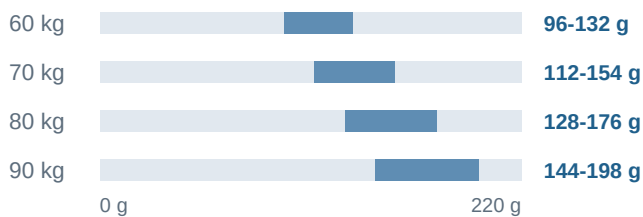
No static stretching before lifting - it slightly reduces force output. If something feels tight, do 1-2 light sets of the movement instead.

Rest periods

Compounds: 2-3 min. Isolation: 60-90 s. Cutting rest on compounds cuts reps on the next set, which cuts total tension - the thing you're chasing. This is the most common efficiency-killer in 'fast' workouts. Keep the whole session under 60 min; long sessions kill morning adherence more than the training does.

Outside the gym

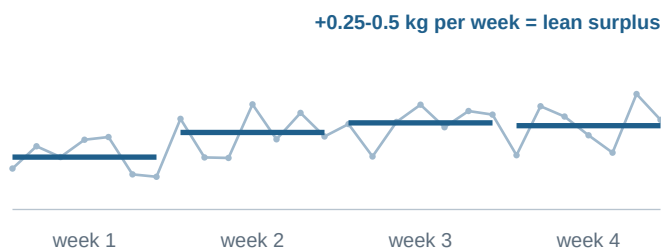
Daily protein target = bodyweight x 1.6-2.2 g



The dose-response for protein flattens around 1.6 g/kg; 2.2 is the safe upper margin. Hit the floor, then fill remaining calories with whatever you can actually eat.

Carbs are not a lever: a 2026 meta-analysis of 11 RCTs (Henselmans et al., Sports Medicine) found no effect of higher vs lower carb intake on hypertrophy once protein was matched. Protein and total calories are what matter.

Bodyweight: judge the weekly average, not the day



Weekly average up **0.25-0.5 kg**. Faster and the surplus is mostly fat; slower and you're spinning wheels on calories. Weigh in the same conditions (morning, after bathroom, before food) and only ever read the weekly line.

Supplements worth the money

Creatine monohydrate

5 g every day, any time, no loading. Cheapest and best-evidenced hypertrophy supplement there is.

Caffeine

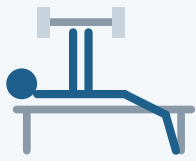
3-6 mg/kg (roughly 200-400 mg) 30-45 min before lifting. Meaningful for morning sessions. Never within ~10 h of bed.

Sleep

Not a supplement, but it outranks everything above. Protect it; it is where recovery actually happens.

Exercise guide

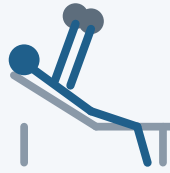
Pictogram plus the key cue for each movement. For a real demonstration, search the grey term on YouTube.



Barbell Bench Press

Lie on a flat bench, bar over chest, press up. Feet planted, slight arch, shoulder blades pinched.

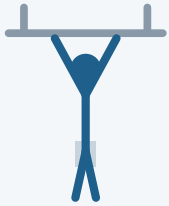
Search: barbell bench press form



Incline DB Press

Bench set to 30-45°, dumbbells pressed from shoulder level. Targets upper chest.

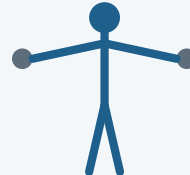
Search: incline dumbbell press form



Weighted Pull-up / Lat Pulldown

Hang from bar, pull chin over it. Add a belt with weight when bodyweight gets easy, or use the pulldown machine.

Search: weighted pull up form



Lateral Raise (DB)

Dumbbells at sides, raise arms out to shoulder height with a slight elbow bend. Light weight, control the descent.

Search: dumbbell lateral raise form



Face Pull

Rope on a cable set at face height; pull towards your face, elbows high, squeeze rear delts.

Search: cable face pull form



Back Squat

Bar on upper back, squat down until thighs are at least parallel, drive up. Knees track over toes.

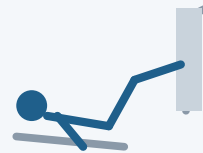
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Romanian Deadlift

Hold bar at hips, push hips back with a flat back and soft knees, lower to mid-shin, stand up. Hamstring stretch is the point.

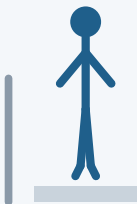
Search: romanian deadlift form



Leg Press / Walking Lunge

Machine: push the platform away with feet shoulder-width. Or lunge forward step by step holding dumbbells.

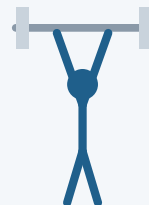
Search: leg press form



Calf Raise

Stand on an edge, rise onto toes, pause, lower below the edge for a full stretch.

Search: standing calf raise form



Overhead Press

Bar at collarbone, press straight overhead until arms lock. Squeeze glutes so the lower back stays neutral.

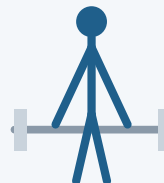
Search: barbell overhead press form



Weighted Dip / Flat DB Press

On parallel bars, lower until upper arms are parallel to floor, press up. Lean forward slightly for chest.

Search: weighted dips chest form



Barbell Shrug

Hold a heavy bar at hips, shrug shoulders straight up towards ears, pause at top, lower slowly. No rolling.

Search: barbell shrug form



Barbell Row

Hinge to ~45°, pull bar to lower ribs, elbows back. Squeeze shoulder blades, don't jerk with the back.

Search: barbell bent over row form



Cable Lateral Raise

Single-arm on a low cable, raise arm out to the side. Constant tension through the whole range.

Search: cable lateral raise form



Farmer's Carry

Pick up two heavy dumbbells, walk 30-40 m tall and braced, set them down. Traps and grip.

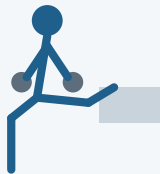
Search: farmers carry form



Deadlift / Trap Bar Deadlift

Bar over mid-foot, flat back, drive through the floor and stand up. Trap bar version is easier to learn.

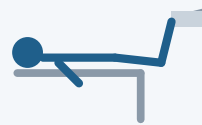
Search: trap bar deadlift form



Bulgarian Split Squat

Rear foot on a bench, lower the front leg until the thigh is parallel, push back up. Dumbbells in hands.

Search: bulgarian split squat form



Leg Curl

Lying or seated machine; curl the pad towards your glutes with your heels, lower slowly.

Search: lying leg curl form



Incline DB Curl

Sit back on a 45-60° incline bench, arms hanging straight down behind you, curl up without moving the elbows. Stretch at the bottom is the point.

Search: incline dumbbell curl form



Overhead Cable Triceps Ext.

Rope on a low cable, face away, arms overhead with elbows by your ears. Lower behind the head, extend up. Stretches the long head.

Search: overhead cable tricep extension form



EZ-Bar Curl

Standing, elbows pinned to your sides, curl the bar up, 2-3 s down. No swinging the torso.

Search: ez bar curl form



Triceps Pushdown

High cable with bar or rope, elbows fixed at your sides, push down until arms lock, control back up.

Search: tricep pushdown form



Neck Curl (flexion)

Lie on your back, head off the end of a bench, plate on your forehead (on a towel), held by both hands. Tuck chin to chest, lower slowly.

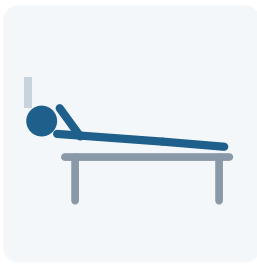
Search: lying neck flexion plate



Neck Extension

Lie face down, head off the end of a bench, plate on the back of your head. Lift your head up, lower slowly. Or use a neck harness standing.

Search: neck extension plate lying



Lateral Neck Flexion

Lie on your side, head off the bench, plate on the side of your head. Raise ear towards shoulder, lower slowly. Both sides.

Search: lying lateral neck flexion plate

Training log - Upper A

Write **weight x reps @ RIR** per set, e.g. 60x8@2. Six-week block; week 6 is the deload. When every set hits the top of the rep range, add weight next week.

Exercise	Set	Wk 1	Wk 2	Wk 3	Wk 4	Wk 5	Wk 6
Barbell Bench Press 3 x 5-8 - RIR 1-2	1						
	2						
	3						
Incline DB Press 3 x 8-12 - RIR 1-2	1						
	2						
	3						
Weighted Pull-up / Lat Pulldown 3 x 8-10 - RIR 1-2	1						
	2						
	3						
Lateral Raise (DB) 4 x 15-20 - RIR 0-1	1						
	2						
	3						
	4						
Face Pull 3 x 15-20 - RIR 1-2	1						
	2						
	3						
Incline DB Curl (superset A1) 3 x 10-15 - RIR 0-1	1						
	2						
	3						
Overhead Cable Triceps Ext. (A2) 3 x 10-15 - RIR 0-1	1						
	2						
	3						
Bodyweight (weekly avg)							

Training log - Lower A

Write **weight x reps @ RIR** per set, e.g. 60x8@2. Six-week block; week 6 is the deload. When every set hits the top of the rep range, add weight next week.

Exercise	Set	Wk 1	Wk 2	Wk 3	Wk 4	Wk 5	Wk 6
Back Squat 3 x 5-8 - RIR 1-2	1						
	2						
	3						
Romanian Deadlift 3 x 8-10 - RIR 1-2	1						
	2						
	3						
Leg Press / Walking Lunge 3 x 10-12 - RIR 1-2	1						
	2						
	3						
Calf Raise 3 x 12-15 - RIR 0-1	1						
	2						
	3						
Neck Curl (flexion) 3 x 15-20 - RIR 2	1						
	2						
	3						
Lateral Neck Flexion 3 x 15-20 / side - RIR 2	1						
	2						
	3						
Bodyweight (weekly avg)							

Training log - Upper B

Write **weight x reps @ RIR** per set, e.g. 60x8@2. Six-week block; week 6 is the deload. When every set hits the top of the rep range, add weight next week.

Exercise	Set	Wk 1	Wk 2	Wk 3	Wk 4	Wk 5	Wk 6
Overhead Press 3 x 6-10 - RIR 1-2	1						
	2						
	3						
Weighted Dip / Flat DB Press 3 x 8-12 - RIR 1-2	1						
	2						
	3						
Barbell Shrug 4 x 10-15 - RIR 0-1	1						
	2						
	3						
	4						
Barbell Row 3 x 8-12 - RIR 1-2	1						
	2						
	3						
Cable Lateral Raise 3 x 15-20 - RIR 0-1	1						
	2						
	3						
Farmer's Carry 3-4 x 30-40 m - RIR heavy	1						
	2						
	3						
EZ-Bar Curl (superset A1) 3 x 8-12 - RIR 1-2	1						
	2						
	3						
Triceps Pushdown (A2) 3 x 10-15 - RIR 0-1	1						
	2						
	3						
Bodyweight (weekly avg)							

Training log - Lower B

Write **weight x reps @ RIR** per set, e.g. 60x8@2. Six-week block; week 6 is the deload. When every set hits the top of the rep range, add weight next week.

Exercise	Set	Wk 1	Wk 2	Wk 3	Wk 4	Wk 5	Wk 6
Deadlift / Trap Bar Deadlift 3 x 5 - RIR 1-2	1						
	2						
	3						
Bulgarian Split Squat 3 x 10 / leg - RIR 1-2	1						
	2						
	3						
Leg Curl 3 x 10-12 - RIR 1-2	1						
	2						
	3						
Calf Raise 3 x 12-15 - RIR 0-1	1						
	2						
	3						
Neck Extension 3 x 15-20 - RIR 2	1						
	2						
	3						
Lateral Neck Flexion 3 x 15-20 / side - RIR 2	1						
	2						
	3						
Bodyweight (weekly avg)							